

Guest Screening: Catch Problems Before They Book

Most cohosts do not screen guests actively. They rely on platform verification, instant-book, and good reviews. That works for most guests. For the 5-10% of bookings that cause real damage, it does not. This module gives you the screening framework that turns a "trust the platform" stance into "trust the platform and verify the high-value bookings".

Who to screen

Not every booking needs screening. Screen the bookings where a bad outcome would hurt you most:

- Stays of 4+ nights (the most common duration for party houses)
- Bookings from accounts with fewer than 2 verified reviews
- Bookings requested for dates within 14 days of arrival (low-lead-time bookings correlate with party bookings)
- Bookings with 6+ guests where the property sleeps 4-6 (watch the headcount, even if the platform doesn't)
- Bookings from outside the country where the property is located (statistical correlation with damage, even when profile looks clean)

The pre-approval message script

Sending this when a high-risk inquiry lands takes 90 seconds and converts either into a safe booking or into a self-cancel. Don't use it as a stalking tactic. Use it as a verification step.

Hi [guest name], thanks for your interest in [property name]! Quick few things so I can confirm you and the property are a good fit:

1. What's the occasion for the trip? (Weddings, birthdays, graduations, etc. — these are not red flags by themselves, but context matters.)
2. How many adults and children will be staying? (Matches what you saw in the booking request.)
3. Have you stayed at a [cabin / urban / etc.] property before? (Optional. New guests are not red flags, but experienced guests tend to treat properties better.)
4. Anything about the property you want to confirm before booking? (Lets them flag unusual needs early — pool heat, parking, pet policy, early check-in.)

Once I have those answers, I'll send a confirmation and we can lock in the dates. Looking forward to hosting you.

How to interpret the answers

Most inquiries respond cleanly within a few hours. Patterns to watch:

- Hesitation to answer any of the four questions = mismatch in expectations
- Headcount on the request doesn't match what they say = misrepresentation; decline and refund
- Aspirational language ("small gathering", "intimate celebration", "quiet birthday") with 8+ guests = high party risk, decline
- Local addresses with short lead-time for weekend stays = sometimes a last-minute party request; ask questions, consider declining

Declining a booking gracefully

If you decide to decline, do it within 24 hours, be polite, refund any platform fees you collected, and offer a reason that's true but doesn't punish the guest (e.g., "the property is not a match for the timing" rather than "I don't trust you"). The platform keeps your decline history. Excessive declines hurt your listing's algorithmic visibility.

If you have a record of declining high-risk bookings, the platform sends you fewer of them. Decline responsibly and you will protect both the property and your own conversion rate over time.

Module 06 — Done. Module 07 covers dynamic pricing — how to set nightly rates that lift revenue without pricing yourself out.